Homosexuality as a Dominant Narrative in *Class*

Netflix series *Class* engages with the intersectionality of identities and the impact of socio-economic backgrounds on the experiences of LGBTQ+ individuals in contemporary India.

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Homosexuality has been a taboo topic in Indian society for a long time, and it is only recently that there has been some degree of acceptance and visibility of LGBTQ+ individuals in mainstream media. Historically, Indian films have shared a complicated relationship with the representation of homosexuality, which is either ignored or ridiculed. Characters who are portrayed as gay or lesbian are frequently portrayed as caricatures, exhibiting exaggerated mannerisms and speech patterns intended for humour, which often perpetuate harmful stereotypes and stigmatises LGBTQ+ individuals.

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Based on the Spanish series *Elite* (2018) and directed by Ashim Ahluwalia, *Class* (2023) is a high-octane thriller that depicts what transpires when three teenagers from disadvantaged backgrounds attend Hampton, a school for the ultra-wealthy in Delhi. The show breaks new ground by intertwining the theme of homosexuality with the show's larger narrative, acknowledging the intersectionality of identities and the impact of socio-economic backgrounds on the experiences of LGBTQ+ individuals. By addressing sensitive social and cultural issues, *Class* reflects an evolving media landscape and tackles homosexuality and romance in adolescents in a country where such topics are often taboo, contributing to a meticulous and empathetic portrayal on screen.

The series features the love story between two young men, Dhruv and Faruq, while delving into themes of class, region, and religion in a contemporary Indian context. Dhruv (Chayan Chopra), a Hampton insider with high parental expectations, encounters Faruq (Chintan Rachchh), a Kashmiri Muslim from an economically disadvantaged family with big dreams. They meet because Faruq has a side business as a drug peddler and Dhruv seeks solace in marijuana. In no time, their relationship veers into taboo territory, flouting homosexual conventions while crossing class, regional, and religious boundaries. It is particularly noteworthy that this tale is woven so easily into the broader narrative of *Class*, without having their inherent queerness minimised or sensationalised as something unusual to be gawked at. The first kiss between Faruq and Dhruv lasts approximately one minute and concludes with Faruq asking, "Why didn't you shave today, Chayan?" The storyline at this point inherently presents several challenges, including the potential for backlash from audiences and critics, navigating the complexities of representing diverse LGBTQ+ experiences, ensuring authenticity, and avoiding stereotypes, while still providing an engaging and entertaining narrative.

Class integrates the LGBTQ+ narrative within the broader context of the show, avoiding the trap of tokenism or marginalisation that is often seen in media portrayals of LGBTQ+ characters. Faruq, for instance, is scarred by the lived memories of his uncle's homophobia. The plot emphasises how one's sexuality is a vital aspect of one's individuality, as well as the necessity of acceptance. Even though the portrayal of the intersectionality of LGBTQ+ experiences is vivid, there is also the reinforcement of the idea that disparities in gay people's coming-out experiences are affected by their religious and socio-economic backgrounds. The love story between Dhruv and Faruq is a powerful example of how personal and political issues intersect, particularly in the context of queer relationships. The way people respond to this relationship is also shaped by social hierarchies.

The Indian media landscape has experienced a slow but significant shift in recent years in the portrayal of LGBTQ+ characters and storylines. While Indian cinema has made some strides in this area, the emergence of web series has opened new possibilities for more inclusive and nuanced representation. One such series is *Made in Heaven* (2019), which revolves around two wedding planners in Delhi, with one of the protagonists, Karan, played by Arjun Mathur, being a gay man. The series explores the complexities of Karan's personal and professional life while also delving into themes of love, acceptance, and societal expectations. The characterization of Kukoo in *Sacred Games* (2018) offered a refined and authentic representation of a transwoman that challenged societal prejudices, albeit unable to shake off the insidious influence of heteronormativity. Despite the frequent depiction of "Hijra" characters as the primary symbol of sexual difference, other portrayals of explicit sexual deviation can be found in popular films. The 1991 film, *Mast Kalandar,* features Anupam Kher as Pinkoo, an effeminate homosexual character. Pinkoo's exaggerated effeminacy is intended to generate humour. This representation of male homosexuality as not only associated with hijra but also as elite, foreign and alien aligns with traditional views of sexuality within nationalist narratives. This observation is not meant as a demand for "positive images" of gay men in mainstream Indian cinema; instead, it suggests that the most intriguing

portrayals of non-heteronormative desire might occur in the absence of clearly defined "gay" and "lesbian" characters. In *Subhah* (1982), a romantic relationship between two female inmates becomes a sensation that attracts media attention and is debated in the legislative assembly. The film addresses sexuality and critiques of homophobia under the umbrella of seemingly more significant issues such as class and gender inequality. Although the conventions of popular films allow for the emergence of same-sex eroticism, it often comes at the cost of the feminine male or masculine female character. The image of queer individuals both adopts and reshapes the representations accessible to them in popular culture to claim even the most improbable public spaces.

Class challenges social conventions and explores the complexities of identity and desire by bringing together two characters from vastly different backgrounds who are drawn to each other despite the obstacles in their path. That said, the series has a tendency to filter its themes through a garish, pulp fiction-inspired plot, which undermines the gravity of the issues being addressed. The show's ambitious selection of themes may also prove to be a double-edged sword, as it may not provide an in-depth exploration of each theme, leaving viewers unsatisfied and craving a more profound understanding of the issues. The series underscores the significant role that the media plays in shaping public attitudes and fostering understanding around LGBTQ+ issues by contributing to the ongoing dialogue on providing a more nuanced, and inclusive representation of diverse sexualities in Indian media.

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